The Book Thief

By Markus Zusak

DEATH:

(Pg 3) ***HERE IS A SMALL FACT***

You are going to die.

Does this worry you?

I urge you – don't be afraid.

I'm nothing if not fair.

I am in all truthfulness attempting to be cheerful about this whole topic, though most people find themselves hindered in believing me. Please, trust me. I most definitely can be cheerful. I can be amiable. Agreeable. Affable. And that's only the A's. Just don't ask me to be nice. Nice has nothing to do with me.

INTRODUCTION

U Krakovianki once stated, "Death is constantly interrupting us – and then the story moves on. The interruptions do not stop the story – it goes on. Some people are no longer a part of the story, but it goes on just the same until death interrupts again: a pattern as old as the world."

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Death is inevitable. We hear about it, witness it, and fearfully wait for it. And though we see it as the enemy, it's a natural part of life. In this selection, by humanizing death and putting a name and face to the "enemy," we are shown that nothing is purely black and white. Death personified is just as affected as we are by occurrences that take place in the novel, The Book Thief by Markus Zusak.

DEATH: (Pg 4-5) I could introduce myself properly, but it's not really necessary. You will know me well enough and soon enough, depending on a diverse range of variables. At some point in time, I will be standing over you. Your soul will be in my arms. A color will be perched on my shoulder [and[I will carry you gently away.

The question is, what color will everything be at the moment when I come for you? What will the sky be saying?

I try to enjoy every color I see – the whole spectrum. A billion or so flavors, none of them quite the same.

My one saving grace is distraction. It helps me cope, considering the length of time I've been performing this job. The trouble is, who could ever replace me? The answer, of course, is nobody, which has prompted me to make a conscious, deliberate decision – to make distraction

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my vacation. Needless to say, I vacation in increments. In colors.

(Pg 6) First up is something white. Of the blinding kind. Some of you are most likely thinking that white is not really a color. Well, I'm here to tell you that it is. White is, without question a color, and personally, I don't think you want to argue with me.

Please, be calm, despite that previous threat.

I am all bluster –

I am not violent.

I am not malicious.

I am a result.

(Pg 9) Next is a signature black, to show the poles of my versatility, if you like. It is the darkest moment before the dawn.

Sometimes I arrive too early.

I rush,

and some people cling longer

to life than expected.

(Pg 11) For just a moment, despite all of the colors that touch and grapple with what I see in this world, I will often catch an eclipse when a human dies.

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I've seen millions of them.

I've seen more eclipses than I care to remember.

(Pg 12) The last [color is] red.

(Pg 14) When I recollect, I see a long list of colors, but it's these three that resonate the most. Sometimes I manage to float far above those [colors]. I hang suspended, until a septic truth bleeds toward clarity.

That's when I see them formulate.

*****THE COLORS*****

RED: WHITE: BLACK.

They fall on top of each other. The scribbled signature black, onto the blinding global white, onto the thick soupy red.

(Pg 174-175) I've seen so many young men

Over the years who think they're

Running at other young men.

They are not.

They're running at me.

(Pg 307-309) I do not carry a sickle or scythe.

I only wear a hooded black robe when it's cold.

And I don't have those skull-like

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facial features you seem to enjoy

pinning on me from a distance.

My travels, what I saw in '42. There's a reason for me explaining what I saw in that time.

There were certainly some rounds to be made that year, from Poland to Russia to Africa and back again. You might argue that I make the rounds no matter what year it is, but sometimes the human race likes to crank things up a little. They increase the production of bodies and their escaping souls. A few bombs usually do the trick. Or some gas chambers, or the chitchat of faraway guns.

So many humans.

So many colors.

And then.

There is death.

Making [my] way through all of it.

On the surface: unflappable, unwavering.

Below: unnerved, untied, and undone.

In all honesty, I was still getting over Stalin, in Russia. The so-called ***second revolution*** – the murder of his own people.

Then came Hitler.

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They say that war is death's best friend, but I must offer you a different point of view on that one. To me, war is like the new boss who expects the impossible. He stands over your shoulder repeating one thing, incessantly: "Get it done, get it done." So you work harder. You get the job done. The boss, however, does not thank you. He asks for more.

(Pg 349) I'll never forget the first day in Auschwitz, the first time in Mauthausen. I picked them up from the bottom of the great cliff, when their escapes fell awfully awry. There were broken bodies and dead, sweet hearts. Still it was better than the gas. Some of them I caught when they were only halfway down. Saved you, I'd think, holding their souls in midair as the rest of their being – their physical shells – plummeted to the earth. All of them were light, like the cases of empty walnuts.

(Pg 336) I carried them in my fingers, like suitcases. Or I'd throw them over my shoulder. It was only the children I carried in my arms.

(Pg 350) I shiver when I remember – as I try to de-realize it.

I blow warm air into my hands, to heat them up.

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But it's hard to keep them warm when the souls still shiver.

God.

I always say that name when I think of it.

God.

Twice, I speak it.

I say His name in a futile attempt to understand. "But it's not your job to understand." That's me who answers. God never says anything. You think you're the only one he never answers? "Your job is to…" And I stop listening to me, because I tire me. When I start thinking like that, I become so exhausted, [but] I'm compelled to continue on, because although it's not true for every person on earth, it's true for the vast majority – that death waits for no man – and if he does, he doesn't usually wait very long.

Please believe me when I tell you that I picked up each soul as if it were newly born. I even kissed a few weary, poisoned cheeks. I listened to their last, gasping cries. Their vanishing words. I watched their love visions and freed them from their fear.

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They were French, they were Jews, and they were you.

(Pg 503) So many people chased after me in that time, calling my name, asking me to take them with me. **(Pg 543)** It has been many years since all of that, but there is still plenty of work to do. I can promise you that the world is a factory. The sun stirs it, the humans rule it. And I remain. I carry them away.

(Pg 549) Yes, I have seen a great many things in this world. I attend the greatest disasters and work for the greatest villains.

But then there are other moments.

There's a multitude of stories that I allow to distract me as I work, just as the colors do. I pick them up in the unluckiest, unlikeliest places and I make sure to remember them as I go about my work.

(Pg 550)

*****A LAST NOTE FROM YOUR NARRATOR*****

I am haunted by humans.

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AWARD HISTORY

IA State Qualifier
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**With minor adjustments by the 4N6 Fanatics staff to ensure correlation with the original text.*

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